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ROOTS OF THE BJP

The Jan Sangh Story

Among the little-known delights of Delhi's parliament building is an exhibition of robotic mannequins for children, showcasing eight politicians who created modern India. At the flick of a button, the figures spring into action one by one, spouting lines about what they stood for. They are part of a light-and-sound display on the foundation story of the republic. One of these eight mannequins is of Syama Prasad Mookerjee, Hindu nationalist ideologue, India's first minister for industries and founder of the Akhil Bharatiya Jan Sangh, which preceded the BJP as India's primary Hindu nationalist party between 1951 and 1977. Mookerjee was one of several non-Congress leaders—like the Constitution-maker B.R. Ambedkar—inducted by India's first prime minister, Jawaharlal Nehru, into his founding cabinet.[1]

Mookerjee, who was acting president of the Hindu Mahasabha during 1940–1944, had joined Nehru's cabinet with 'specific approval' from the Mahasabha's driving force, Hindutva ideologue Vinayak Damodar Savarkar.[2] He served most of his ministerial term as a vice president of the Hindu Mahasabha before exiting the outfit because it refused to allow membership to non-Hindus.[3] Later, Mookerjee quit the Nehru government over the protection of Hindus left behind in East Pakistan. He is now enjoying a revival of iconicity since the Modi government came to power.